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Charles Burgess (1808-53), the author of *A Brief Notice...*, was probably the first Englishman to trade with Iran through the Black Sea. Although the eldest son of a prominent London banker, Charles Burgess first traveled to Iran in 1827 not as a trader but as a young military adviser in Prince Abbas Mirza's new army (*Nizam-i Jadid*). He served as an infantry officer for two years until financial and political pressures forced Abbas Mirza to dismiss most of his British advisers. Left without an army commission, Charles Burgess turned to trade, raised capital from both his family and local money-lenders, and persuaded his younger brother, Edward, to join him in Iran to help organize his multi-faceted business enterprises. The Balkan upheavals of 1835-6, however, wrecked many of his commercial ventures. Forced into bankruptcy, Charles Burgess returned to Britain, but left his brother as a "hostage" for his Iranian creditors.

Stranded in Iran, Edward Burgess began a varied but highly interesting career. He worked first as a government supervisor of two Assyrian villages in western Azerbaijan; then as a foreign-language tutor to the royal princes; later as a custodian of the royal stables in

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Tabriz; and, eventually, when Naser al-Din Shah ascended the throne, as both court translator and official editor of the state gazette entitled *Ruznama-i Vagayi-i Itti-faqiyya* (Journal of Occasional Happenings). By the late 1840s, he had paid off his family debts but remained in Iran because of his deep attachments to the country. He died in Tabriz in 1855.

While in Iran, the two Burgess brothers wrote frequent descriptions of their experiences. Many of their reports have been published by Benjamin Schwartz under the title of *Letters from Persia Written by Charles and Edward Burgess, 1828-1855* (New York: New York Public Library, 1942). This volume, however, did not include the *Brief Notice*.... Charles Burgess had prepared the *Brief Notice*... in 1832 in the hope that his friend in the House of Commons, T. H. Villiers, would publish it as a Parliamentary Paper. But Villiers' death in the same year ended this hope. Although a few copies of the *Brief Notice*... were published privately in 1833, very few seem to have found their way into public archives and university libraries. One copy, however, was given by the Burgess family to the New York Public Library and is now kept in the rare manuscript room of the same library.